was / were: what Murphy does not tell you

Day 2 · Grammar beyond Murphy

Murphy first
Murphy red, Unit 10 (pages 30–31): do **10.1, 10.2** in class, **10.3** at home. Unit 38 (pages 86–87): **38.1** at home. Do **not** use 38.3: it needs grammar the class has not learned.
This file adds five things the book does not explain.

1 · Past time words

yesterday · last night · last week · last year · **two days ago** · in 2020 · when I was a child · at 8 o'clock yesterday
*I **was** in Tashkent **two days ago**. We **were** at school **yesterday morning**.*

ago always goes after the time: two years ago (not ago two years).

2 · Handy phrases with was / were (the book gives the form, not these everyday sentences)

How was your weekend? → It was **great** / **OK** / **not bad** / **terrible**.
What **was it like**? → It was **lovely**. Who **was** that? → That **was** my cousin.
I **was born** in Samarkand in 2008. I **was** late / ill / busy / tired.
That **was** a good idea! It **was** a mistake.

3 · there was / there were: a lot of

With things you can count: *There **were** a lot of people.* With things you cannot count: *There **was** a lot of traffic. There **was** some water.*
Questions and answers: *Was there a bank? Yes, there was. / No, there wasn't. Were there any shops? Yes, there were.*

4 · Then and now

*Now there **is** a big shop here, but ten years ago there **was** a small park.*
*Today there **are** a lot of cars. In 1950 there **weren't** many.*

This is the most useful way to use there was / there were: compare the past and the present.

5 · The Russian trap

Russian has no "is / was" with weather and time. English must have **it**:
«Вчера было холодно.» → *It **was** cold yesterday.* (not Was cold yesterday)
«Было поздно.» → *It **was** late.* «Был дождь.» → *It **was** rainy. / There **was** rain.*

And never I ~~was be~~. One verb: I was.

Practice

Day 2 · Practice 1

What to do: Exercises 1–2 in class, alone, then check. Exercise 3: the class translates aloud, one sentence each.

1 Choose the correct time word

1. We were in Samarkand (yesterday / tomorrow).
2. My grandfather was a teacher (ago / many years ago).
3. It was very cold (last winter / next winter).
4. Where were you (last night / now)?
5. My parents were at work (two hours ago / two ago hours).
6. I was in Moscow (in 2019 / on 2019).
7. She was ill (last week / this week), but she is better now.
8. They were here (an hour ago / after an hour).

2 Answer about YOU: yes / no + one more sentence (Yes, I was. I was at the cinema.)

1. Were you at home last night?
2. Was your last holiday good?
3. Were your parents at work yesterday?
4. Was it hot yesterday?
5. Was there a lot of traffic this morning?
6. Were you late for class today?

3 Translate into English

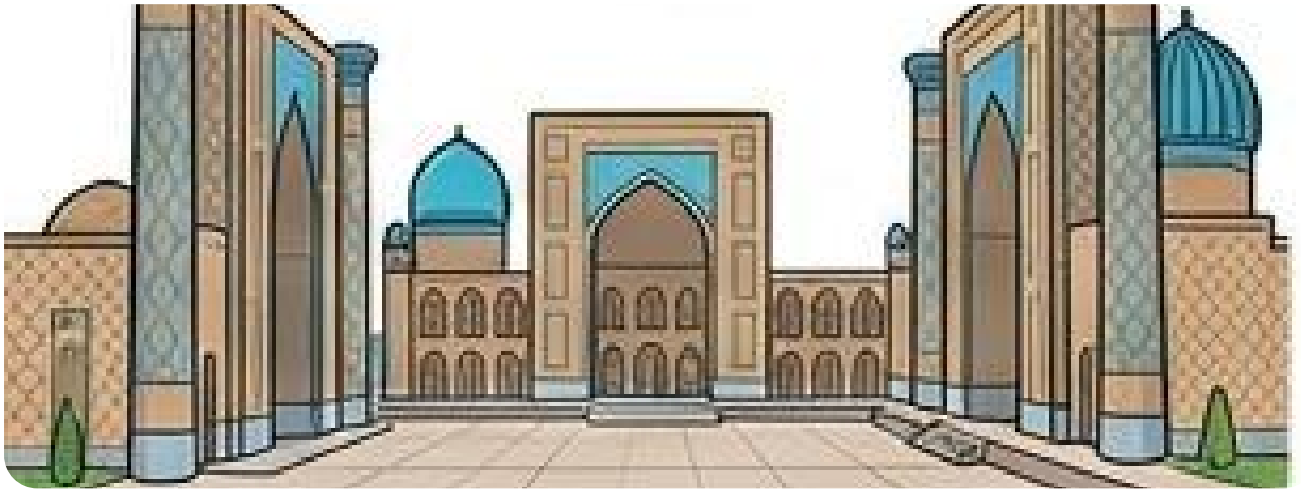
1. Вчера было жарко.
2. Два дня назад я был в Бухаре.
3. Здесь был большой рынок, а теперь здесь парк.
4. Было много людей и много шума.
5. Вы были дома вчера вечером? — Да.
6. Было поздно, и на улице никого не было.
7. Где вы были в 2020 году?

Practice 2

Day 2 · Practice 2

What to do: Alone, then read your sentences aloud.

4 Samarkand then and now



This is the Registan today. Write 4 sentences with there is / there are. Then imagine the same place 500 years ago: write 4 sentences with there was / there were / there weren't.

5 Complete the story: was / were / there was / there were

Last summer my family and I (1) _____ in Bukhara. It (2) _____ very hot, but the old city (3) _____ beautiful. (4) _____ a lot of tourists, and (5) _____ many small shops. My little brother (6) _____ hungry, but (7) _____ any cafés near the hotel. Finally we found a café. The food (8) _____ good, and the people (9) _____ friendly. (10) _____ a better holiday?

Answers · Day 2 grammar

For the teacher

1 yesterday · many years ago · last winter · last night · two hours ago · in 2019 · last week · an hour ago

2 Own answers: check the short answer (Yes, I was. / No, I wasn't.) and one more sentence.

3 It was hot yesterday. · Two days ago I was in Bukhara. · There was a big market here, and now there is a park. · There were a lot of people and a lot of noise. · Were you at home last night? — Yes, we were. · It was late, and there was nobody in the street. · Where were you in 2020?

4 Own answers: today with there is / are; 500 years ago with there was / were / weren't (There weren't any cars).

5 were · was · was · There were · there were · was · there weren't · was · were · Was there